

Left in a house, not a home

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Left in a house, not a home

by [Iriascend](#)

Summary

Dick and Tim have an emotional talk about their relationship and what it means to be a family.

Notes

I'm having a breakdown and I'm going to make it everybody else's problem.

Inspiration drawn from:

[this](#) tumblr post by petrighara

The Good Place S3E06 "A Fractured Inheritance", specifically [this](#) scene.

["Brother"](#) song by Mads Buckley

Tim hisses in pain when Dick dabs at the wound. The older man smiles apologetically.

“Just a little longer, I promise,” he reassures Tim quietly. “You’re going to be good as new when I’m done.”

“Until the little demon strikes again,” Tim snarls, turning his gaze away. There’s more disdain in those words than usual, which makes Dick stop for a moment.

“It’s pretty normal for brothers to fight, you know.”

“I’m pretty sure that despite the name, the Cain Instinct doesn’t usually include murder attempts.”

“He’s been through a lot,” Dick admits with a sigh. “He needs time to… readjust.”

Tim immediately sends him a dirty look. “How much time, exactly? This isn’t the first time he stabbed me.”

“Give him some slack. He’s not evil; he’s just thirteen.” Dick reaches out to put a gauze over the now-clean cut on Tim’s shoulder, but the boy smacks his hands away. He stands up, clearly very upset, and looks Dick in the eye with a deep frown.

“I know. I know! He’s a League baby, he’s thirteen and traumatized. I know!” Tim throws his arms out in anger, then starts pacing around for a while. He flinches away every time Dick makes any sort of movement, so he can only watch, worrying about the wound starting to bleed again. Then, Tim whips around to face Dick again and picks the tirade back up. “And Jason was just seventeen and traumatized. I know! I’ve read enough therapy books to realise that I shouldn’t… I shouldn’t blame them. I know!”

“Tim, I—” Dick starts, reaching out to his brother again.

The boy takes a step back. “No! You- just- shut up!” Tim closes his eyes and wraps his arms around himself. Dick desperately wants to hug him but knows he would just agitate Tim more. “You *left*, Dick! Every time! When I tried to help Bruce after Jason died and when Bruce disappeared, when Gotham collapsed and when Damian nearly killed me— You left. You leave me in this dumpster fire to handle it on my own. Every. Goddamn. Time. ”

“I—” Dick stutters out, not even knowing how to defend himself. Tim isn’t wrong, but his accusations aren’t based on facts or logic, they’re based on emotions, on being hurt and betrayed. And Dick can’t- *won’t* argue with feelings. “I— I admit that I… avoid a lot of difficult topics. I wasn’t the best brother or mentor I could’ve been. I wasn’t even *good*. But I changed. I took up the cowl—”

Tim frowns, and Dick worries that it might not have been his best response. “Yeah. You did. I don’t know if I could shoulder *that* too.”

Dick breathes out the slightest sigh of relief.

“But that’s the worst part. “

Dick’s heart stills.

“You did that *for Damian*. If you’ve truly changed, then you were always capable of change. You were always capable of being a good, protective older brother. I just wasn’t worth changing for. Even now. You’re defending *him*. But I’m also just seventeen, Dick.”

Suddenly, Tim collapses to the ground, once again wrapping himself in his own arms. “I’m **also just seventeen!** Why do their traumas have to become *my* traumas?! Why do I not get to be just a kid?! Why do I always have to be the bigger person?!”

Every sentence Tim yells out, tears slowly gathering in his eyes, feels like a cold steel dagger through Dick’s heart. He dives towards the boy at record speed, catching him and hugging him as hard as he possibly can. Tim starts sobbing, shaking in his arms. “Shh, Tim, I’m here-”

“I’m just seventeen. I don’t deserve it.”

“You don’t.”

“Then why-... why did you leave me?”

Dick is silent for a while. Finally, he decides he’s not going to be a coward anymore.

“Because I was too scared of burning myself with the fire you had to endure. And I’m so, *so* sorry.”

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